Storing Client Belongings

Guidance for caring for client belongings at shelter sites

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, Mass Care Chief, Shelter Shift Supervisors, AD Logistics

Considerations

- Clients often arrive at evacuation and emergency shelters with their belongings during a disaster. The volume of possessions is likely to depend on how much evacuation warning was provided.
- Shelter managers and staff support clients in caring for their belongings during their stay at the shelter.
- Storing client belongings within the dormitory creates challenges with space, security, safety, and access. To avoid these issues, what a client may bring into the dormitory is typically limited to what they can fit under their cot.
- In some cases, it may be necessary to provide limited storage space at the shelter for additional belongings.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards:**
  - Shelter Operations
  - Household Pets and Service Animals
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards

What to do

Choose storage options to be used

Under Cot Storage

- Logistics can obtain under-cot storage boxes or alternative (one per cot) for those who need them.

Storage Outside the Shelter

- Storage of personal belongings outside the shelter facility is preferrable.
- Client's store possession in their private vehicles located outside the shelter.
- Clients may keep their belongings in personal utility trailers in the shelter parking lot when there is enough space.
- Personal belongings should NOT be stored in tents or under tarps outside the shelter as they are unsecure and may become wet, moldy or smoky and unusable or a health hazard.

Indoor Storage within the Shelter Facility

- During the opening inspection, the Shelter Site Manager identifies a secured indoor area suitable for storage of client belongings.
    - This should be a locked room or storage area.
    - Establish an agreement and procedure for storage with the facility manager.

Secured Outdoor Storage

- In situations where indoor storage is not available, consider requesting a lockable shipping container or box truck to provide storage space outside the shelter.
- The Shelter Site Manager discusses such a need for HQ Sheltering Manager, who can make a request to Logistics.
- When such storage is provided, follow the directions for managing Red Cross provided storage.

Establish storage area space and identify resources needed for storage

- Determine the maximum storage space allocation per client by dividing the square footage of the storage area by the projected number of clients requiring storage.
- Determine what types of items can be stored by clients (for example: suitcases, foot lockers, boxes, baby strollers, and bicycles etc.) and post this information where all clients can view.
    - Do not allow storage of items such as open food containers, drugs, weapons, and flammable or other dangerous material.

- If the storage area is large, the Shelter Site Manager creates a floor plan to organize stored goods for easier recovery.
    - Use painter's tape to mark space allocation and walk-ways.
    - Use an alphabetic system, marking areas with letters (for storage by last name) or a numbering system with areas marked by numbers or if large enough, use alpha-numeric system (like A1, B2).

- If needed, the Shelter Site Manager should request 20- to 50-gallon plastic totes from Logistics and determine how many to allocate to each household with belongings to store (like 4 per household or 2 per client).

Identify Space and Resources Needed for Storage

- Develop a shelter specific storage plan that outlines procedures for clients to access their belongings that are in the storage location.
- Label each stored item (container, box, bag, bicycle, etc.) with the client's full name and contact information including cell phone number.
- Record details of items that clients place in the storage area as a comment in the client record in SCIA.

Control Access to Storage Area

- A Red Cross worker must always accompany clients when accessing the storage area.
- Only one client along with a Red Cross worker is allowed to access the storage area at a time.
- The Red Cross worker confirms that the client accesses only their belongings by asking for ID.
- Provide the client a reasonable amount of privacy while still maintaining security.

Control Access to Storage Area

Suspected Prohibited Items

- When it is suspected that a storage container has prohibited items, the Shelter Site Manager contacts the Sheltering Activity Manager and onsite security.
- A Shift Supervisor or Shelter Site Manager, along with onsite security, conducts and documents an inspection conducted with the client present unless client has left the shelter.
    - Use disposable gloves during the inspection. Safety gloves or double gloves are recommended to protect against needles or other sharp objects.

Abandoned Items

- If client abandons or appears to have abandoned stored items:
    - Call the client at their contact number and place a time limit for picking up items.
    - Document the contact as a comment in the client's record in SCIA.
    - If the client is unreachable, a Shift Supervisor and a second Red Cross worker open, inspect, and inventory the contents to prepare it for disposal.

- If the client does not retrieve their belongings by the deadline:
    - Take photos of the stored items with the name visible before opening the container.

- Provide the inventory with photos to the Shelter Site Manager for inclusion in the Manager's Log.
- Relocate the container to a designed holding area for final disposition.

Related Articles

Sharing Key Information Between the Shelter and the HQ Sheltering Manager
Types of information and methods of communication shared between shelters and DRO headquarters.

Determining Shelter Layout
Details on effectively establishing a physical organization of a shelter site in order to deliver services to standards

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Posting Signage at Shelters
Instructions for posting signs at key shelter locations to provide information for clients and workers

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Mass Care Toolkit
Overview of Mass Care guidance and resources with links to more specific information

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

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